

■ Raising Baby Chicks!

Ms. Wotkyns' Classroom Chick Care Guide

Kittridge Elementary STEM School • Van Nuys, CA

Your chicks have hatched — now YOU are their caregiver and scientist! ■
This guide will help you keep them warm, fed, healthy, and happy from Day 1 all the way to moving outdoors.

■ Section 1: Setting Up the Brooder

■ How Much Space?

- Give each chick at least $\frac{1}{2}$ –**1 sq ft** for the first 2 weeks, then more space as they grow.
- Use a large plastic tote, cardboard box, or wooden brooder box.
- Add a **wire lid** once chicks get active — they can jump out faster than you'd think!

■ Bedding

- Best choices: **pine shavings** or hemp bedding (2–4 inches deep).
- For the **first 3 days**, lay paper towels on top so chicks learn to eat feed, not the bedding!
- **Never use** cedar shavings (toxic!), newspaper (too slippery), or sand for tiny chicks.
- Spot-clean daily and do a **full bedding change every 3–5 days** — wet bedding spreads germs!

■ Keeping Chicks Warm

- **Week 1:** Keep it 95°F right under the heat lamp — like a warm sunny spot!
- Lower the temp by **5°F each week** until chicks are fully feathered (~6 weeks).
- Use a red heat lamp bulb or a brooder plate — **red bulbs are safer than white!**
- ❄️ ■ Always leave a **cooler zone** in the brooder — chicks move around to control their own temperature.

■ How Do You Know If the Temp Is Right?

- Huddling tightly under the lamp = TOO COLD ■
- Panting and moving away from lamp = TOO HOT ■
- Spread out, active, and peeping happily = JUST RIGHT ■

■ **Safety Tip: Always secure heat lamps with a chain or extra clip — lamp fires can be very dangerous!**

■ Section 2: Water

Fresh, clean water is one of the most important things for healthy chicks!

- Use a **chick waterer with a shallow trough** — deep water can be dangerous for tiny chicks.
- Place **marbles or clean pebbles** in the trough for the first week — extra safety!
- **Change water at least once a day** — more often if it gets dirty.
- Keep the waterer **near — but not directly under — the heat lamp**.
- For the first 1–3 days, add **poultry electrolytes** to the water to help chicks stay strong.
- **Raise the waterer slightly** (on a small block) to keep bedding out of the water.

■ **Important: A wet or chilled chick can get very sick very fast — check the waterer every day to make sure it isn't leaking!**

■ Section 3: Feeding Your Chicks

■ ■ What to Feed — and When

- **Days 1 – 8 weeks:** Chick Starter feed (18–20% protein). Medicated starter helps prevent a disease called coccidiosis.
- **Weeks 8–18:** Chick Grower/Pullet feed (16–18% protein). **Do NOT give layer feed yet** — too much calcium can hurt their kidneys!
- **18 weeks+:** Layer feed (16% protein + calcium). Add oyster shell for extra calcium when they start laying eggs!

■ Feeding Science Tips

- ■ Keep feed available **all the time** — chicks eat many small meals throughout the day.
- Use a **chick feeder** to reduce waste and keep feed clean.
- Offer **chick grit** (tiny granite pieces) once chicks eat anything besides starter feed.
- **Keep feed dry!** Wet feed grows mold quickly and can make chicks very sick.

■ **Never feed layer feed before 18 weeks — the high calcium can permanently damage a chick's kidneys!**

■ Section 4: Chick Health — What to Watch For

■ Signs of a Healthy Chick

- Active, curious, and running around the brooder.
- ■ Eating and drinking regularly.
- Clear, bright eyes — no goop or crustiness.
- Clean bottom (no droppings stuck to feathers).
- Standing steady — no wobbling or falling over.
- Peeping contentedly — not screaming or distressed.

■ Common Problems & What to Do

■ Problem	■ Symptoms	■ What to Do
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Pasty Butt	Droppings caked over bottom	Gently clean with warm water; check brooder temp
Coccidiosis	Bloody poop, tired, hunched over	Use medicated feed; treat whole group with Corid NOW
Spraddle Leg	Legs splaying out sideways	Non-slip bedding; hobble legs with vet wrap 24–48 hrs
Wry Neck	Head twisted or tilted back	Vitamin E + selenium; see a vet for serious cases
Pecking	Feather picking, blood on chicks	Reduce crowding; use red bulb; add enrichment
Breathing Issues	Wheezing, rattling, runny nose	Isolate chick; improve ventilation; call a vet
Chilling	Lethargic, cold, piling up	Warm slowly under lamp; check brooder temp right away

■ Coccidiosis Warning!

Coccidiosis is one of the biggest dangers for young chicks. Look for bloody or watery droppings, tiredness, ruffled feathers, and not eating. Act fast — treat the whole group with **Corid** in the water. Medicated feed helps *prevent* it but won't cure an active outbreak!

■ Section 5: Week-by-Week Care Timeline

■ Age	■ Temp	■ Feed	■ What's Happening?
Week 1	95°F	Medicated Starter	Arrive! Dip beaks in water; paper towels over shavings
Week 2	90°F	Starter	Wing feathers growing! Very active — remove paper towels
Week 3	85°F	Starter	Tail feathers emerging; expand brooder space
Week 4	80°F	Starter	Feathering speeds up; pecking order forms
Weeks 5–6	75°F	Starter → Grower	Almost fully feathered; short outdoor time on warm days!
Weeks 7–8	65–70°F	Grower	Fully feathered! Can move outside if weather is mild
Weeks 9–18	Outside	Grower/Pullet	Living outside permanently; slowly meet the adult flock
18 weeks+	Outside	Layer Feed	First eggs coming! Usually 18–24 weeks depending on breed ■

■ Section 6: Moving Chicks Outside

- Start with **short supervised outdoor trips** on warm days (65°F+) from Weeks 4–5.
- Move outside **permanently once fully feathered** — usually 6–8 weeks.
- ❄ ■ If nighttime temps drop below **50°F**, young pullets still need supplemental heat.
- **Introduce grass and soil gradually** — sudden exposure can trigger coccidiosis in unvaccinated birds.

■ Joining an Existing Flock

- **Never put baby chicks directly with adult chickens** — they can get hurt!
- Wait until pullets are at least **12–16 weeks old** before introducing them.
- Use the '**see but don't touch**' method: separate with wire mesh for 1–2 weeks first.
- Introduce at **nighttime** when birds are calm; have multiple food and water stations.
- Some pecking is normal — only step in if a bird is actually **bleeding**.

■ Expert Chicken Keeper Tips! ■

- **Handle chicks every day from Day 1** — friendly chicks grow into friendly chickens!
- **Keep a Chick Journal!** Write down temperatures, observations, and behavior every day — that's real science!
- At Week 2, add a **small clump of grass or dirt** to the brooder — introduces good microbes and entertains the chicks!
- Hang a small **head of cabbage or bundle of greens** in the brooder as a toy to prevent boredom pecking.
- Chicks are **vulnerable to hawks and predators from above** — always cover outdoor runs!
- Keep **Corid on hand** before you need it — coccidiosis can spread very fast!
- The first eggs from young hens are often **small or double-yolked** — totally normal!
- Chickens **molt (lose feathers) once a year**, usually in fall — this is normal, not a health problem.
- Fresh herbs like **oregano, thyme, and lavender** in the coop are natural germ-fighters and bug repellents!
- **Never use scratch grains as the main diet** — they're a treat, not a complete food.

■ Happy Chick Raising, Scientists! ■

Guide adapted for Ms. Wotkyns' Class • Kittridge Elementary STEM School • Van Nuys, CA

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